

Watercolour

The term 'watercolour' refers to both a type of paint and the artwork made with it. The paint is made of pigments mixed with gum arabic and thinned with water. Usually fluid and translucent, some pigments are more opaque than others. Variations of watercolour have been used for centuries, from ancient Egypt to the Byzantine and Romanesque eras. It was also used extensively for medieval manuscript illumination, while some of the earliest Chinese artists painted on silk with water-based inks and dyes. Dürer used watercolour in several works, and by the 18th century, many young men recorded their Grand Tours in watercolour.

Initially, artists ground their own watercolours from natural pigments, but in 1784, William Reeves invented small, hard cakes of soluble watercolour, and from the 1830s, portable, moist watercolours in porcelain pans were available. From the late 18th to the mid-19th century, the market for domestic art contributed to the growing popularity of watercolours. In Britain, this period was later known as the Golden Age of Watercolour.



Turner, *Clare Hall*, 1793